

3.4.2 Strategies for production

Research and experience show that people who communicate effectively in a foreign language tend to make good use of systematic and efficient verbal and non-verbal strategies in order to get meaning across, in spite of their imperfect command of the language.

Individual students may fail to learn, or forget language items required by some test items, or they may wish to attempt to go beyond the demands of the specification in completing the task set.

In these circumstances, the following strategies can prove useful. They fall into two main categories: non-verbal and verbal. The non-verbal strategies described below are clearly of limited value in the speaking tests of this examination; they may, however, prove useful to the learner.

3.4.2.1 Non-verbal strategies

Pointing and demonstration

Accompanied by some appropriate language (eg *jak to, podobne do tego, jak to się nazywa?*)

Expression and gesture

Accompanied where appropriate with sounds (eg 'Oh!' which, with appropriate intonation, facial expression and gestures can convey such attitudes and functions as pain, surprise, anger, fear, pleasure and admiration).

Mime

This again can be accompanied by appropriate sounds and language, and can sometimes help communication to be maintained when it might otherwise break down. This strategy has obvious limitations in an oral test which is recorded and assessed on the basis of the recording.

Drawing

Can be an efficient strategy with some tasks (especially written) and can convey both attitude and information (eg J or L a diagram showing how to get from one point (eg a station) to another (eg a home)).

3.4.2.2 Verbal strategies

Using a word which refers to a similar item

Using a similar word to the one the speaker/writer wishes to refer to, but for which he/she has forgotten the word (eg *filizanka* for *szklanka*, *kwiat* for *róża*, or *ojciec i matka* for *rodzice*). This strategy is not always effective and its use would be assessed according to its effectiveness in a particular context.

Description of physical properties

Using description to refer to something of which the name has been forgotten (eg *jest okrągłe; to, na czym się siedzi przy stole; mała owca; owoc, który Ewa dała Adamowi*). The physical properties refer, for example, to colour, size, material, position and shape. Again, the use of this strategy in an exam would be assessed according to its communicative effectiveness.

Requests for help

Can include requests for translation (eg *Jak się mówi po polsku ... ?*) and questions which make no reference to English (eg *Jak się ta maszyna nazywa? Jak to się pisze?*) Use of this strategy in the exam will not allow students to be given full credit. However, it is clearly preferable to use such requests for help than for communication to break down and its use will be assessed according to the context. When requests for help with specific problems occur, the teacher should maintain the role of a sympathetic native speaker and help accordingly. The teacher should, of course, avoid taking over from the student and carrying out the tasks set.

Simplification

When a learner avoids the use of a form of which he/she is unsure (eg *chcę zrobić* instead of *chciałabym zrobić* or *może wpadniecie do nas* instead of *może wpadlibyście do nas*). When such simple forms are used correctly and appropriately they will be awarded high marks. Correct and appropriate use of more complex forms will also be rewarded. A systematic use of simplified forms may reduce error, facilitate communication and increase fluency, but if overused, this strategy may result in students failing to make full use of their capabilities.

Paraphrase

Where a student uses words and messages in acceptable Polish, avoiding the use of words which he/she has forgotten (eg *ona nie ma męża* or *jest panną; podobne do..., wygląda tak jak..., ma przeciwne znaczenie co...*). When used well, this strategy communicates the message effectively to a sympathetic native speaker and such use in an exam would be assessed accordingly.

Reference to specific features

A learner may use this strategy to describe something of which he/she has forgotten the name (eg *zwierzę z długimi uszami; kwiat, który ma kolce*). This strategy is often quite effective, and effective use would be assessed accordingly in an exam.

Reference to the function of an object

Similarly a student may refer to the actions that can be performed with an object whose name he/she does not know (eg *coś, co się używa do otwierania butelek*). This is a commonly used strategy which is usually effective in communicative terms.

Another strategy sometimes used by language learners is word coinage, the creation of words based either on English or Polish words. This strategy usually produces words which do not exist in Polish or which, if they do exist, have a different meaning from the one intended. The use of this strategy is rarely effective in promoting communication and students would be well advised to use it only if all other strategies fail.

Another commonly used strategy is topic avoidance, when the student ignores or abandons a topic because of inability to deal with it. Use of this strategy in the exam will not allow the student to be given full credit. Use of it in a learning situation will reduce opportunities for the development or expansion of the student's repertoire. It is, therefore, a strategy which should be discouraged, as a basic condition for communication strategies to have a potential learning effect is that they are governed by achievement, rather than avoidance behaviour. Approaches which lay more stress on correctness than on communication will tend to encourage the use of avoidance strategies.

Appropriate use of the dictionary will help students to tackle particular difficulties and help eliminate the need to resort to avoidance.

Evidence suggests that the availability of a range of strategies such as those outlined above, and flexibility in their use, represent an important advantage in overall communicative effectiveness. It also appears that the most effective strategies demand some linguistic proficiency and that the more proficient speakers are also better at using communication strategies effectively. The development of such strategies cannot, therefore, be seen as encouragement not to develop linguistic knowledge as much as possible. Strategic competence is not a substitute for vocabulary learning, for example, but a useful supplement. Indeed, all language users make use of communication strategies, even in their first language, and really successful strategies usually pass unnoticed.